

# **GOD IS BIGGER THAN MY ANXIETY**

A Faith-Based CBT Workbook for Christian Teens

You are not alone. God gets it.

**By Daniel Tesfamariam**

# **GOD IS BIGGER THAN MY ANXIETY**

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**If you are in crisis: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline**

This workbook does not replace professional help.

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# WHAT IS ANXIETY?

(And why does it feel so awful?)

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Anxiety is your brain's alarm system going off - even when there's no fire.

It can feel like:

- Your heart racing
- Can't catch your breath
- Stomach in knots
- Mind won't stop racing
- Wanting to hide or run away

HERE'S THE TRUTH:

- You are NOT crazy
- You are NOT weak
- You are NOT a bad Christian
- Anxiety is super common in teens (you're not alone!)

WHAT GOD SAYS:

'For I am the LORD your God who takes hold of your right hand and says to you, Do not fear; I will help you.' - Isaiah 41:13

# GOD GETS IT

## Jesus Felt Anxious Too

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In the Garden of Gethsemane (Matthew 26:36-39), Jesus felt:

- 'Sorrowful and deeply distressed' (v.37)
- So stressed his sweat was like drops of blood (Luke 22:44)
- He asked God to take the cup away (v.39)

Jesus - God in human form - experienced extreme distress.

He didn't sin. He prayed. He was honest with God.

This means:

- Feeling anxious is NOT a sin
- God understands exactly how you feel
- You can be honest with God about your fears
- Jesus is not disappointed in you

'For we do not have a high priest who is unable to empathize with our weaknesses.' - Hebrews 4:15

Write: When have you felt like God didn't understand?

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# MY ANXIETY PROFILE

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Let's figure out YOUR anxiety. Check what applies:

- ☐ I worry about school/grades
- ☐ I worry about what people think of me
- ☐ I have trouble sleeping because of worry
- ☐ I avoid social situations
- ☐ I get nervous before tests/presentations
- ☐ I worry about my family
- ☐ I feel like something bad will happen
- ☐ I check my phone constantly for messages
- ☐ I have panic attacks
- ☐ I worry about the future

**My anxiety is worst when:**

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**My body feels it here:**

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On a scale of 1-10, my average anxiety level is: \_\_\_\_

# THINKING TRAP: CATASTROPHIZING

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What it is: Thinking the worst will happen

Example: 'If I fail this test, my life is over!'

## **BIBLICAL TRUTH:**

Truth: Matthew 6:34 - Don't worry about tomorrow. Each day has enough trouble.

## **REFRAME:**

Reframe: 'One test doesn't define my future. God has plans for me.'

## **YOUR TURN:**

A time I fell into this trap:

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The truth I can tell myself instead:

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A verse that helps me:

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# THINKING TRAP: MIND READING

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What it is: Assuming you know what others think

Example: 'Everyone thinks I'm weird.'

## **BIBLICAL TRUTH:**

Truth: 1 Samuel 16:7 - People look at the outside; God looks at the heart.

## **REFRAME:**

Reframe: 'I can't actually read minds. Some people might like me!'

## **YOUR TURN:**

A time I fell into this trap:

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The truth I can tell myself instead:

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A verse that helps me:

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# THINKING TRAP: ALL-OR-NOTHING

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What it is: Everything is either perfect or terrible

Example: 'I got a B. I'm a total failure.'

## **BIBLICAL TRUTH:**

Truth: Romans 3:23 - All fall short. Grace is for imperfect people.

## **REFRAME:**

Reframe: 'A B is good! I don't have to be perfect to have value.'

## **YOUR TURN:**

A time I fell into this trap:

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The truth I can tell myself instead:

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A verse that helps me:

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# THINKING TRAP: FORTUNE TELLING

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What it is: Predicting the future negatively

Example: 'I know the party will be awkward.'

## **BIBLICAL TRUTH:**

Truth: James 4:14 - You don't know what tomorrow brings.

## **REFRAME:**

Reframe: 'I've been surprised before. It might actually be fun.'

## **YOUR TURN:**

A time I fell into this trap:

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The truth I can tell myself instead:

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A verse that helps me:

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# THINKING TRAP: FILTERING

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What it is: Only seeing the negative

Example: '20 people liked my post but 1 didn't - I'm unlikable.'

## **BIBLICAL TRUTH:**

Truth: Philippians 4:8 - Think on what is good, lovely, praiseworthy.

## **REFRAME:**

Reframe: 'Let me focus on the 20 who liked it!'

## **YOUR TURN:**

A time I fell into this trap:

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The truth I can tell myself instead:

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A verse that helps me:

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# THINKING TRAP: SHOULD STATEMENTS

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What it is: Rigid rules for yourself

Example: 'I should always have it together. Christians don't struggle.'

## **BIBLICAL TRUTH:**

Truth: 2 Corinthians 12:9 - God's power is made perfect in weakness.

## **REFRAME:**

Reframe: 'It's okay to struggle. That's when God shows up most.'

## **YOUR TURN:**

A time I fell into this trap:

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The truth I can tell myself instead:

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A verse that helps me:

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# MY BRAVE LADDER WITH GOD

Face your fears one step at a time - with prayer at each step!

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|                             |       |         |       |
|-----------------------------|-------|---------|-------|
| <b>Step 10 (Fear: 100%)</b> | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 9 (Fear: 90%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 8 (Fear: 80%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 7 (Fear: 70%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 6 (Fear: 60%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 5 (Fear: 50%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 4 (Fear: 40%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 3 (Fear: 30%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 2 (Fear: 20%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |
| <b>Step 1 (Fear: 10%)</b>   | _____ | Prayer: | _____ |

Start at step 1. You've got this. God's got you.

# MY CALM-DOWN TOOLKIT

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## **BREATHING (4-7-8):**

Breathe in for 4... Hold for 7... Out for 8...

## **5-4-3-2-1 GROUNDING + GOD IS HERE:**

5 things I can SEE (God made each one)

4 things I can TOUCH (God is near)

3 things I can HEAR (God speaks peace)

2 things I can SMELL (God provides)

1 thing I can TASTE (taste and see God is good!)

## **MY SCRIPTURE EMERGENCY KIT:**

Psalm 56:3 - When I am afraid, I will trust in you.

Isaiah 41:10 - Fear not, for I am with you.

Philippians 4:6-7 - The peace of God will guard your heart.

# SOCIAL MEDIA & ANXIETY

## A Faith Perspective

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Social media can increase anxiety because:

- Comparison (but see Galatians 6:4 - test your own work)
- FOMO (but see Psalm 16:5 - God is your portion)
- Cyberbullying (but see Psalm 27:1 - God is your light)
- Always 'on' (but see Mark 6:31 - come away and rest)

HEALTHY BOUNDARIES:

- No phone 1 hour before bed
- Unfollow accounts that make you feel bad
- Set time limits on apps
- Remember: people post highlights, not reality

MY SOCIAL MEDIA PLAN:

Time limit per day: \_\_\_\_\_ minutes

Accounts to unfollow: \_\_\_\_\_

My phone-free times: \_\_\_\_\_

What I'll do instead: \_\_\_\_\_

## WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 1

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| Day | Anxiety(1-10) | Brave thing I did | God moment |
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**This week I'm proud of:**

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**Next week I want to try:**

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## WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 2

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| Day | Anxiety(1-10) | Brave thing I did | God moment |
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**This week I'm proud of:**

**Next week I want to try:**

## WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 3

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| Day | Anxiety(1-10) | Brave thing I did | God moment |
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**This week I'm proud of:**

**Next week I want to try:**

## WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 4

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| Day | Anxiety(1-10) | Brave thing I did | God moment |
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**This week I'm proud of:**

**Next week I want to try:**

## WEEKLY CHECK-IN - WEEK 5

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| Day | Anxiety(1-10) | Brave thing I did | God moment |
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**This week I'm proud of:**

**Next week I want to try:**

# MY SAFETY PLAN

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**Warning signs that I'm not okay:**

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**Things I can do to calm down:**

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**People I can talk to:**

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**Adults who can help (parent/teacher/pastor):**

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**My therapist/counselor:**

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**Crisis number: 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline)**

**My reason to keep going:**

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**God's promise to me:**

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# RESOURCES

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988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741

NAMI (National Alliance on Mental Illness): [nami.org](http://nami.org)

Your church youth pastor or counselor

School counselor

Christian counseling: [faithfulcounseling.com](http://faithfulcounseling.com)

## A LETTER FROM GOD TO YOU:

Dear one, I see you. I know you're scared.  
I am not angry at you for feeling anxious.  
I made you, I know you, and I am with you.  
You are brave for picking up this book.  
I will never leave you or forsake you.  
One day at a time. I've got you.  
- Your Heavenly Father

(Isaiah 43:1, Psalm 139, Deuteronomy 31:6, Hebrews 13:5)